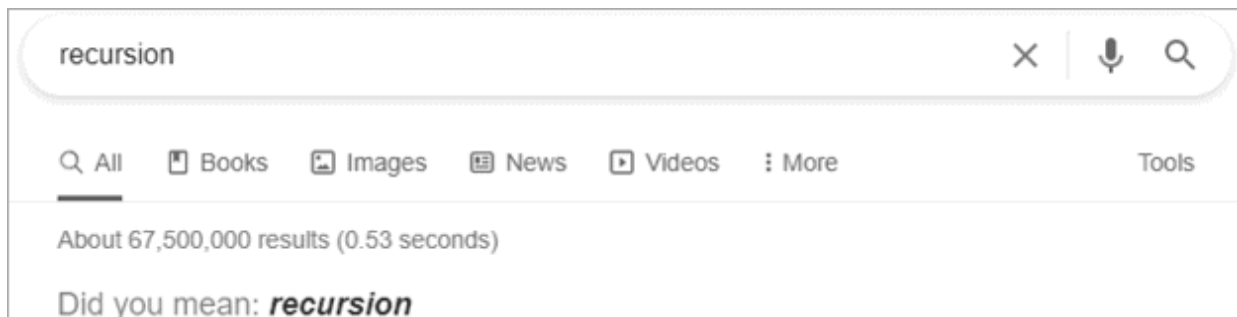


The Definition of Recursion

Before we begin, let's get the clichéd recursion jokes out of the way, starting with this: “To understand recursion, you must first understand recursion.”

During the months I've spent writing this book, I can assure you that this joke gets funnier the more you hear it.

Another joke is that if you search Google for *recursion*, the results page asks if you mean *recursion*. Following the link, as shown in [Figure 1-1](#), takes you to . . . the search results for *recursion*.



[Figure 1-1](#): The Google search results for recursion link to the Google search results for recursion.

[Figure 1-2](#) shows a recursion joke from the webcomic xkcd.